



An Invitation to Discover Japan

By Ruth Shiraishi

From a business perspective, I have heard Japan described as the "Undiscovered Planet". I think that description fits perfectly with this country in every way, as I find myself discovering more beauty and deeper meaning in my surroundings.

The initial impression of Japan from overseas would be a multicolored kimono made of delicate silk, the sloping magnificence of a snow-capped Mount Fuji, a wave of businessmen pushing into an overloaded commuter train or towering silver buildings gleaming against a clear blue sky. These images are just the beginning of all the wonder Japan has to offer. When I was working at a Japanese company in Ginza some 20 years ago, I could go for weeks without seeing another "foreign" face. Now, the same Ginza area is an oasis for foreign visitors and I constantly find myself offering directions to excited tourists pouring over their maps and guidebooks. Japan is still an "undiscovered planet" in many ways, but it has become a visitor-friendly destination filled with surprises and truly unforgettable experiences. Get ready for a wonderful adventure in Japan any time of year.

JANUARY

During "O-shogatsu" (New Year), Japan takes a long-awaited rest. Visitors can experience unusually empty trains, quiet streets and special meals at hotels. Join in a traditional "Mochi Pounding" event where neighborhoods gather to make fresh rice cakes. You will never forget the taste of fresh, warm rice cakes filled with sweet azuki bean paste.

FEBRUARY

The winter sky shines brightest. Visit the famous Tokyo Tower for a rare view of the city. Built in 1958 and modeled after the Eiffel Tower in Paris, the observatory space soars 825 feet. Also, Enoshima island features a little-known but unforgettable lookout point. Amid this expansive garden at the top of the island and above a famous Shrine, is a 59.8 meter-high tower. With a birds-eye view of expansive ocean and far inland towards Yokohama and Tokyo, this experience will literally take your breath away.

MARCH

As buds appear on bare branches of city trees, hints of spring abound. Watching one of the six Grand Sumo tournaments held annually can be an exciting feature to any Japan visit. In March, the tournament is held in Osaka (about three hours by bullet train from Tokyo). With strong roots in Shinto ritual, the pageantry and history you will feel at Sumo is difficult to replicate. Another wonderful experience is Japanese Tea Ceremony, "Sado". This simple art-form centers on